AxarquíaHome



2026-2027 EDITION

Checklist: looking after your home in the Axarquía while you are away

Closing up, getting ready for winter, preventing damp, pool and land, security and insurance, and what to do when you come back.

Canillas de Albaida

Welcome to the Axarquía

White villages against the mountains, terraces full of olive, almond and avocado trees, and a coastline of little coves beneath the cliffs. The Axarquía, east of Málaga, is one of the most beautiful places in Andalusia to live.

With around 300 days of sunshine a year, Málaga airport about an hour's drive away and villages such as Frigiliana, Cómpeta and Nerja, it is easy to see why so many Dutch, German, Swedish and British people have a home here. A house in this region does need the right approach, and that is what this checklist helps with.



Frigiliana on the mountainside



Nerja



Cómpeta

> Many houses in the Axarquía stand empty for part of the year. That is fine as long as all goes well, but a leak, a blocked drain after a storm or mould from a closed cupboard can then go unnoticed for weeks. The damage is often many times bigger than the problem itself.
>
> With this checklist you close up the house properly, know what needs doing each season and find it as you left it when you return. Hang it by the door or keep it in the kitchen drawer.



Canillas de Albaida

1. Before you leave

Half an hour of work that saves a lot of trouble.

- [ ] Main water tap off (leave irrigation or pool on only if someone checks them)
- [ ] Water heater and water pump off
- [ ] Fridge empty, clean and door ajar, or left running with drinks only
- [ ] Plugs out, except router, alarm and any cameras
- [ ] Windows and doors closed, shutters half or fully down
- [ ] Cushions, parasols and loose items inside or tied down
- [ ] Rubbish gone and no food that attracts pests
- [ ] Cupboard doors ajar and a moisture absorber or dehumidifier in closed rooms



Steps in the old quarter of Frigiliana

2. Roof, gutters and drains

Most damage in the Axarquía comes with the first heavy rain in autumn.

- [ ] Gutters, drains and roof terrace outlets cleaned before October
- [ ] Roof terrace checked for cracks in tiles or finish
- [ ] Sealant around windows and doors checked
- [ ] Chimney swept if you have an open fire or wood burner
- [ ] Drainage around the house clear, so water does not stand against the walls
- [ ] After a storm or heavy rain: someone who goes to look



Frigiliana

3. Damp and ventilation

Old houses with thick walls get cold and damp in winter when they stand empty.

- [ ] House aired every week or two, ideally on a dry, sunny day
- [ ] Dehumidifier draining into the sink in the dampest room
- [ ] Mattresses and cushions upright or under a breathable cover
- [ ] Condensation on windows and mould behind cupboards checked
- [ ] White façade and walls checked for flaking paint: a sign of damp
- [ ] With recurring stains: have the cause found instead of painting over them

What you would rather spot in time

A leak or condensation that goes unnoticed for weeks turns into expensive damage. If someone checks every two weeks, it is caught in time.



A leak: a damp stain in the corner of the ceiling



Condensation on the glass and mould in the corner beside a window, with a cloth on the sill to catch the water



Cómpeta and the Sierra Almijara

4. Pool, garden and land

- [ ] Pool winterised or maintenance arranged; pump and chlorine checked
- [ ] Irrigation on a timer, with a leak check on the water meter
- [ ] Land around the house clear of dry grass and scrub: compulsory in wooded areas
- [ ] Olive, almond or avocado trees pruned at the right time
- [ ] Pine processionary caterpillars removed in spring: dangerous for dogs and children
- [ ] Access road checked after heavy rain
- [ ] Solar panels cleaned a few times a year: Saharan dust costs output



Nerja

5. Security and insurance

- [ ] Alarm or camera with alerts on your phone, and someone who can go and check
- [ ] Timer switch on a few lamps
- [ ] Locks and fittings in good order; spare key with someone you trust
- [ ] Phone numbers of neighbours and your key holder to hand
- [ ] Policy read: is there a maximum period the house may stand empty, or required checks?
- [ ] Photos kept of the contents and the condition of the house
- [ ] Letterbox emptied or post forwarded

6. When you come back

- [ ] Water meter checked before opening the main tap, and again afterwards for leaks
- [ ] Water heater and pump on, taps run for a moment
- [ ] House aired well and checked for damp, mould and pests
- [ ] Air conditioning filters cleaned before the warm months
- [ ] Gutters and roof terrace checked after the winter
- [ ] Small defects noted and repaired before they get bigger



The village square of Canillas de Albaida

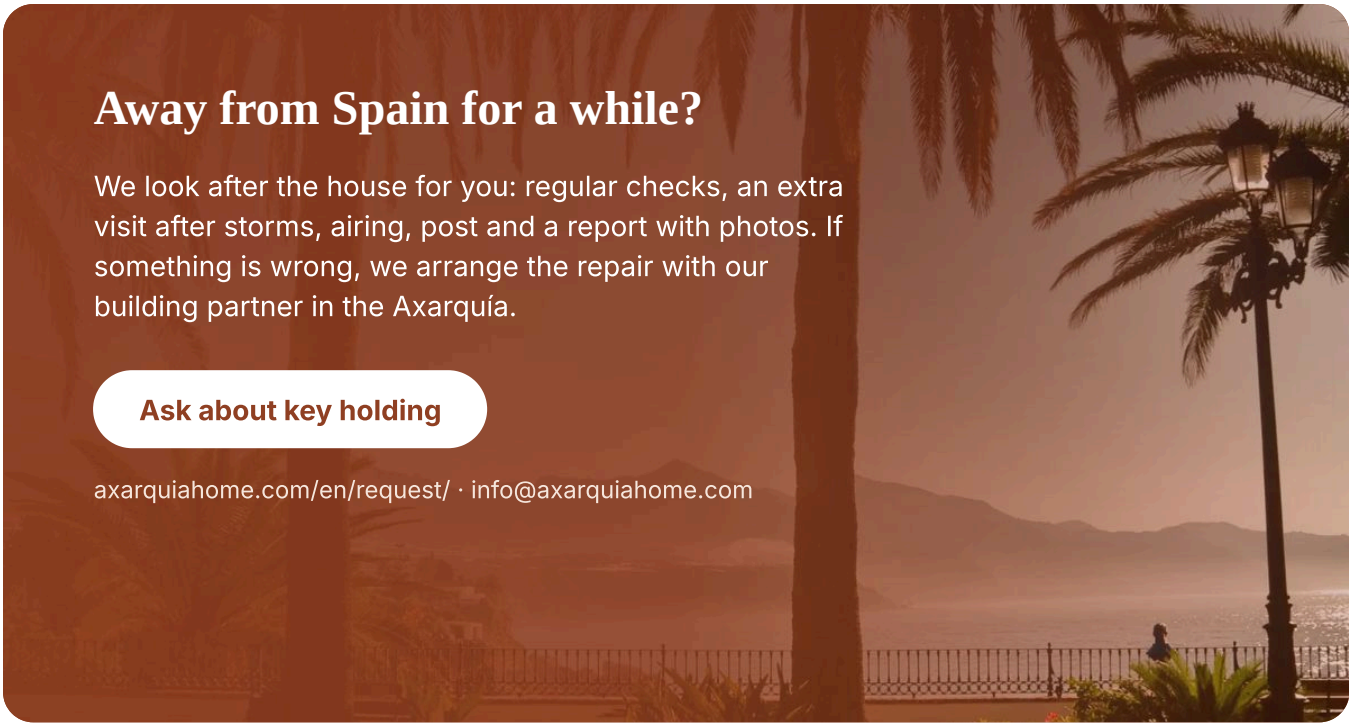
7. Questions to ask

Your key holder

1. How often do you visit, and what do you check?
2. Do I get a report with photos after each visit?
3. Do you also go and look after a storm or heavy rain?
4. What do you do in case of a leak or power cut?
5. Do you arrange repairs, and up to what amount without asking?
6. How do you keep my keys?
7. What does it cost per month, and what is extra?
8. Are you insured if something goes wrong?

Your insurer

1. How long may the house stand empty before cover lapses?
2. Are checks by a key holder required?
3. Is water damage from a burst pipe covered?
4. Is storm damage to roof and terrace covered?
5. Is theft covered if there are no signs of forced entry?
6. What must I do in case of damage, and within what time?
7. Are the contents insured for the right value?
8. Does the policy still apply if I rent the house out?



This checklist gives general information. Insurance terms and local rules differ; always read your own policy.